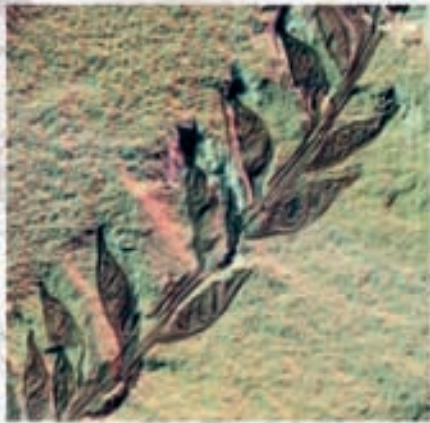


Flowering plants

It's hard to imagine a world without flowering plants, but today's colorful varieties only began to emerge during the last age of the dinosaurs, the Cretaceous Period.



The beginnings

The earliest flowering plant yet identified is *Archaeofructus sinensis* or “ancient fruit,” which was small, low growing, and straggly, and not like the colorful plants of today. It dates back around 125 million years.



When did petals appear?

Early flowers lacked petals and when they did first appear, they were tiny. Petals created more variety, as plants began to compete for attention from insect pollinators.



What is pollination?

Most flowering plants don't produce seeds unless a dustlike substance—pollen—is transferred from one flower to another. Pollen can be carried by wind or by animals such as bees, which are rewarded with nectar.

◀ *ROBINIA* is a flowering tree native to North America. It is also called a locust.

An old friend

Magnolias color our world today, but they were also familiar to the dinosaurs. They began to appear in the middle of the Cretaceous Period, spreading because they grew quickly, which was a defense against being eaten by dinosaurs.

